FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The upcoming assembly elections would generally qualify for the tag of being "the semi-finals". Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Telangana are not only prized provinces; their results can profoundly affect the political momentum going into the 2024 general election. However, experience forbids us from making a simplistic cause-and-effect equation. The first three states voted one way in 2018 and unambiguously in the opposite way months later in 2019. If one wagers that 2023 and 2024 could differ, the hypothesis still awaits proof. And yet, a black swan event like the Pulwama attacks had intervened last time. History need not repeat itself. There's also a specific moment of political novelty that perceptibly heightens the stakes this time for the two main combatants: the Narendra Modi-led BJP that rules at the Centre and the Congress that is positioning itself as the primary challenger.

Despite being hobbled by incumbency fatigue in Rajasthan and to a lesser degree in Chhattisgarh, it's after years that the Congress is going into any election with some wind in its sail. Ever since the success of the Bharat Jodo Yatra one year ago, fortunes have taken a somewhat virtuous turn for the Grand Old Party. It won Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh, and now it leads a grand Opposition alliance in the shape of INDIA. It is not an eventuality anyone could have foreseen even months ago. On top of that, the Congress is using these elections as a test case for the slogan it has lately been championing: the caste census. Whether making a powerplay or defending against odds, it's using its newfound OBC card to minimise damage and maximise benefit.



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The BJP will be more than keen to thwart any real or rhetorical advantage to the Congress for precisely the same reasons. It would like to both abort the Congress's headway and neutralise any sign of ground support for Indian politics reorienting itself around a caste census. The party's trump card here is not the local leadership but Prime Minister Modi himself, whose presidential-style campaigning extends to assembly elections. With his image reinvigorated around a successful G20 summit and the Women's Reservation Bill, the party will want outcomes matching the high investment. Moreover, the four big poll-bound states account for a massive bloc of 82 Lok Sabha seats—Rajasthan 25, MP 29, Chhattisgarh 11 and Telangana 17. The first three, which operate within a strict binary politics, contribute one-third of the 186 or so Lok Sabha seats that will see direct bipolar contests between the Congress and the BJP in 2024.

At the state level, these elections will decide the fortunes of many heavyweights and be the last hurrah for some. Most chief ministers in the fray are fighting for relevance. In rough order of difficulty, it would be Shivraj Singh Chouhan, K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), Ashok Gehlot and, lastly, Bhupesh Baghel, who seems the most comfortably placed. Add to this former chief ministers Vasundhara Raje, Raman Singh and Kamal Nath and you have an exciting mix. There's also a Young Turk, former deputy CM Sachin Pilot, seemingly frozen into his own enforced hibernation. Toss in CM aspirants, and the list expands considerably to take in sundry satraps and even a few Union ministers. All this is not counting Mizoram CM Zoramthanga, who is fighting off a stiff challenge from the Zoram People's Movement in a context that includes intense shades of geopolitics via a Kuki-Chin-Zo refugee influx from Myanmar, which also ties it to the incendiary situation in neighbouring Manipur. These elections will decide the political fate of many of these veterans.

At the level of personal careers, MP CM Chouhan is in a particularly tough spot. He is only 64 years old. That's over a decade away from his party's official age for entering political sanyas. He has been chief minister four times already. In fact, he has been such a consistent and reliable performer that he was once seen as a prime ministerial probable. Modi's arrival on the national stage thwarted that possible future for good. Now, all signals are that he is fighting with his back to the wall, even if his party wins. Though the party has had to rely on him as the leading local face, the BJP has significantly fielded as many as eight Lok Sabha MPs in the state, including three Union ministers in Narendra Singh Tomar, Prahlad Patel and Faggan Singh Kulaste, as also national general secretary Kailash Vijayvargiya. Their ambitions will undoubtedly exceed that of merely becoming the MLAs for the Dimni, Narsinghpur, Niwas or Indore 1 seats they have been fielded from.

In Rajasthan, 72-year-old Gehlot is seeking to buck both history and anti-incumbency with a bid to be CM a fourth time. For nearly three decades, the state has voted out the incumbent regime. And the Gehlot regime has been embroiled in corruption charges, which it's attempting to counter with doses of welfarism. It is an open question whether this strategy will work in his favour or it may be too late. But the outcome will also be affected by the fortunes of his 70-year-old predecessor Vasundhara Raje, whether her party gives due importance to her leadership potential. Despite the lack of a clear alternative, the BJP central command has stopped short of declaring her as their CM face.

Age limits may not apply to the 69-year-old KCR in Telangana, but his Bharat Rashtra Samithi, renamed to reflect national ambitions, ironically finds itself besieged in its backyard. The mood of anti-incumbency, propelled by charges of corruption and nepotism, gives an opening to the other two contenders—the Congress and the BJP. The Congress, it seems, after a long eclipse, could be a serious challenger. Less than a decade after its formation in 2014, the state awaits one more chapter in the flux between the regional-national balance in Indian politics.

This week's cover story, with Executive Editor Kaushik Deka in Delhi, Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon in Hyderabad, Deputy Editor Rohit Parihar in Jaipur and Senior Associate Editor Rahul Noronha in Bhopal and Raipur, encompasses all ends of the reportage spectrum, and kickstarts a season of election coverage lasting till December. The import of these elections will surely spill over the provincial bounds and flood the national imagination. Stay tuned.



(Aroon Purie)